

Big portal in bigger China

Sina.com, a popular Web site in China, has joined about 200 Internet portals to form a search engine alliance that seeks to challenge global giants such as Google. The search engine is developed by the China Internet Information Centre and a Chinese firm called Sinobet. It links to a database of more than 30,000 mainland portals.

Of late, China has been blocking access to popular sites

such as Google and AltaVista, which has led to the demand for reliable search engines. Sina hopes that more than 60 per cent of users will use its search engine, compared with 10 per cent now. The search engine is free for Internet surfers, but firms need to pay to be linked to the database.



The alliance denied being part of a government move to replace Google, even as it hoped to achieve a 20 per cent market share in the mainland this year. A representative said the timing of Google's access problems and the launch of the search alliance was a coincidence.

Dial-a-flu

A populace jittery over the SARS (Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome) outbreak in Hong Kong can find some solace in an unlikely source. A mobile operator has launched a location-sensitive service that will alert subscribers near buildings struck by the deadly flu virus. Those opting for the service will have their phones tracked, and will be

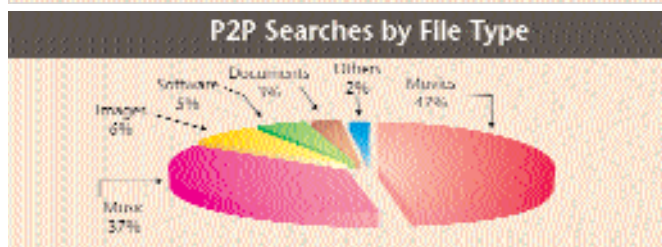
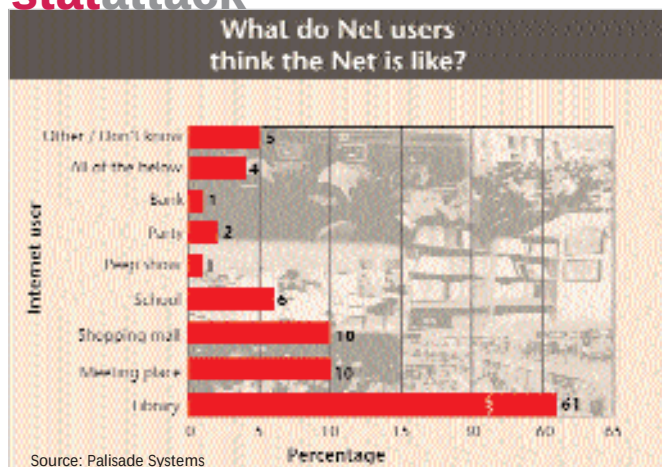
told by SMS which buildings within a kilometer of their location have had SARS cases occur. The managing director of Sunday Communications, the company offering the service, claims that subscribers can get the peace of mind needed to resume their everyday lives.

Users can dial a number to access the information posted

by the Department of Health and then choose to subscribe to the SARS location alerts.

Sunday will also donate mobile services to SARS patients. The company is one of six mobile operators fighting for a slice of the cellular pie in a competitive market with one the highest mobile penetration rates in the world.

statattack



INFOGRAPHICS: Sachin Dalvi

India matters

SAP, Germany-based software company reportedly plans to spend \$120 million over the next 3 years on growing its business in India. This bands the company along with several high-profile technology companies that plan to, or already have, set up operations here. The company plans to direct the funds primarily toward marketing and sales initiatives, with the intention of tripling business in India over the next three years. SAP has a software development centre that employs more than 500 people. The company is in the process of moving to a 15-acre campus that can house up to 1,000 people.

redalert

Flaws in media players

Two popular media players, the RealOne player and QuickTime player have serious security flaws that put millions of users at risk.

The security hole, in RealNetwork's media players, can be caused by a specifically corrupted PNG (Portable Network Graphics) file. A successful exploit could let a hacker execute arbitrary code on a user's machine. Updates for the players are available at www.real.com.

The Apple QuickTime media player has an unrelated security flaw. If users happen to load a specially created exploit URL, remote hackers could execute arbitrary code on their machines. Apple has recommended that all users upgrade to version 6.1, available at <http://www.apple.com/quicktime/download/>

IRC Backdoor

There is a new Backdoor Trojan in town called Backdoor.Sdbot.H. Once infected, it allows a hacker to remote control a computer by using Internet Relay Chat (IRC). The existence of the file I3Explorer.exe is an indication of a possible infection. The Trojan auto-updates itself, adds several entries to the system Registry and infects the System directory files. All versions of Windows are at risk of getting infected with it. It can spread through IRC and e-mail. Users are strongly advised to update their anti-virus definitions and block suspicious attachments. Symantec has provided an advisory page at <http://www.symantec.com/avcenter/venc/data/backdoor.sdbot.h.html>

■ The early reports about SARS came from Internet discussions ■ Electronic Arts to promote Nvidia products